Whether this conversation ever took place, Pollock certainly welcomed Fatteh Jang and from the first treated him with deference, giving him the same honours that Macnaghten had accorded to Shuja when he travelled through the same valley to retake his throne three years earlier. Privately, however, Pollock wrote dismissively of 'the unhappy prince . . . a slender and rather good-looking young man, but neither gifted with brains, nor entitled to much respect on the score of morality – apparently a reference to the Shah's predilection for "amusing himself with the occasional homosexual rape on members of the garrison" when stationed in Kandahar in 1839–40'.[73] Pollock also wrote that he deliberately withheld from the Shah the fact that the British were planning to withdraw from Kabul after they had achieved the limited objectives Ellenborough had set for them: defeating Akbar Khan, liberating the hostages and prisoners of war, recovering as many sepoys as possible and punishing the Afghan tribes for their perceived treachery.[74]

A week later, on 8 September, Pollock's force marched out of Jagdalak towards the mouth of the Tezin Pass, ready for the final push on Kabul. Sniping from the hilltops increased in intensity as the day progressed and, as darkness fell, fire from unseen jezails peppered the camp, despite Pollock having carefully placed pickets on all the peaks round about. 'The troops were of course turned out and kept on alert,' wrote Lieutenant Greenwood in his diary. 'The enemy continued firing into the camp from every height that was not absolutely in our possession; and their bullets were flying like hail among our tents. The sides of the hill were illuminated in every direction by the constant flashes of their jezails and the muskets of our piquets.'[75] The following morning at daybreak, Pollock's scouts brought in the news that Akbar Khan, supported by Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai and Aminullah Khan Logari, had moved forward from the positions they had prepared in the Khord Kabul and were now massing their 16,000 troops just ahead of them on the heights of Tezin.

Pollock split his force into three columns, with columns made up of kilted Highland Scots and long-robed Afghan jezailchis mounting the slopes on either side of the pass and with the guns and the cavalry of the advance guard moving cautiously along the valley floor under the direction of General Sale. 'We moved forward in column without seeing any indication of any enemy,' recounted Greenwood. 'We had proceeded about two miles into the defile, when suddenly a long sheet of flame issued from the heights